CHAPTER 5

TEHREEK-E-TALIBAN PAKISTAN (TTP)

Since 2002, some groups of tribesmen in FATA had been supporting the Afghan Taliban and Al Qaeda elements that escaped the US onslaught in Afghanistan (Yusuf & Adkin, 2007). These tribesmen, mostly Sunni Muslims of Deobandi sect, joined hands and formed Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) (Religious Students' Movement of Pakistan) on 14 December 2007. It was led by Baitullah Mehsud, who became a prominent figure after the death of famous militant tribal leaders Nek Muhammad Wazir and Abdullah Mehsud (Defence against Terrorism Review, 2008). Thus, the TTP rose from the rank of foot soldiers of Al Qaeda to an independent force, definitely backed by Al Qaeda, to implement its agenda. The reasons for the birth of TTP are historical, local and global.

Unlike Afghan Taliban, TTP activists were not students of madrasahs. However, they adopted this name to take advantage of the branded name to get quick recognition and support of the Pashtuns of the tribal areas in particular and the people of Pakistan in general.

The objectives of TTP were resistance against the Pakistani security forces, enforcement of *Sharia* in Pakistan and supporting Afghan Taliban against NATO forces in Afghanistan (Council on Foreign Relations, 2008). In one interview, Baitullah Mehsud declared that his ultimate aim was to carry out attacks in New York and Washington: 'Our main aim is to finish Britain and the United States and to crush the pride of the non-Muslims. We pray to God to give us the ability to destroy the White House, New York and London' (*The News International*, 2009).